

FREE AND REDUCED MEAL APPLICATION FAQs

Where do I find the online Free and Reduced application?

Log into your Infinite Campus parent portal (preferably on a computer)
<https://ic.sd25.us/campus/portal/parents/pocatello.jsp> > “More” > “Meal Benefits” > choose link to start meal application.

What measures can I take to expedite my application?

An online application will expedite your application because it is received in the office immediately upon submission and is much quicker to process than a paper application.

Do I need to fill out an application for each child?

No. Complete one application for all students in your household. We cannot approve an application that is not complete, so be sure to fill out all required information.

Who can receive free meals?

There are several ways that your child may be eligible for meals free of charge. Your child can get free meals if your household income is within the free limits on the Federal Income Guidelines.

If one member of your household is currently receiving assistance (benefits) from one of the following Programs: Food Stamps, FDPIR, or TANF, all children in the household are eligible for free meals. (Remember, a household is defined as “...a group of related or non-related individuals, who are not residents of an institution or boarding house, but who are living as one economic unit.”

Foster children (who are a ward of the court) are eligible for free meal benefits. Eligibility does not extend to other members of the household.

If you are receiving benefits through the state (i.e. SNAP food stamps, TANF, or Foster through the state) you should receive a letter indicating a direct certification. If you receive a letter, you do not need to fill out an application. If your benefits are received from the tribal government (i.e. FDPIR, TANF, or Foster through the tribe) you must fill out an application with your FDPIR or TANF case number listed or the Foster box checked in order to receive free meals. The state does not have access to those people receiving benefits from the tribal government and cannot notify us of a direct certification.

Have the eligibility guidelines changed from last school year?

Yes the eligibility guidelines have changed from last year and you do need to fill out a new application if you feel you still qualify for the meal benefits.

Can homeless, runaway, and migrant children get free meals?

Yes. However, this is not a self-determined status. If you feel that you qualify for homeless, runaway, or migrant status please contact your local school secretary or Student Support Services at the district office.

I got a letter saying my children are approved for free meals for this school year. Should I fill out an application?

All applications MUST be renewed every new school year. Please carefully read the letter you received and follow the instructions. Call the School Food Service if you have questions. If you received a letter for the current school year, then no, you do not have to fill out a new application. (Just make sure that all of your children are listed on the letter as being eligible to receive free meals.)

Who can receive Reduced Price meals?

Your child can receive low cost meals if your household income is within the reduced price limits on the Eligibility Guidelines. Please fill out an application.

I receive WIC (Women, Infants and Children) benefits. Can my child get free meals?

Children in households participating in WIC may be eligible for reduced price or free meals based on income. Please fill out an application.

Will the information I give be checked?

Yes, we may ask you to send written proof of the information you give.

If I don't qualify now, may I apply later?

You may apply at any time during the school year. If you have already filled out an application but were denied you do not need to fill out a new application, you may request an amendment to the original application. In order to amend your original application from the same school year you will need to provide your proof of income to District 25 Food Service office.

What if I disagree with the school's decision about my application?

You should talk to a school official. You also may ask for a hearing by calling or writing to the School District Business Operations coordinator.

Who should I include as members of my household?

Include yourself, all children who live with you and all other people living in your household, related or not (such as grandparents, other relatives, or friends).

What if my income is not always the same?

Please contact the School Food Service for further instructions. Normally you will list the amount that you normally receive BEFORE deductions. For example, if you normally receive \$1,000 each month, but you missed some work last month and only got \$900, put down that you get \$1,000 per month. If you are normally paid for overtime, include it.

Are applications available in other languages?

Applications are available in English and Spanish. Applications may also be available in other languages upon request.

Why is it necessary to use the same name as it appears on the Birth Certificate?

Since the School District uses the birth date and name information from the Birth Certificate for all school records. The only way the application can be validated is by using the same information. Clearly, nicknames and family abbreviations will slow down the application process.

Why do you list All Other Household Members?

The consideration for approval of an application is based on income and the number of household members. Therefore, it is required to list all members of the household.

Why do I need to fill out the last 4 of the Social Security Number and sign the application?

These two sections are required fields and it is very important that these sections be completed. If this information is not completed, **the application will be denied.**

If I have more than one student going to school in the School District do I need to fill out more than one application?

No, only complete ONE APPLICATION PER FAMILY.

If I have a student living at home that goes to a private school, charter school, or Pre-K school, should I include them on the application?

Yes, include them in the student (child) section of the application.

Direct Certification

What is Direct Certification?

Under direct certification, school districts use information from the State Social Service Department to certify children to receive free meals. To qualify, the children's families must receive assistance from Food Stamps or TANF. In addition, Foster students who are a ward of the state court will be direct certified. Those receiving Food Distribution on Indian Reservations (FDPIR) or Foster and a ward of the tribal court are also eligible for free meals but will need to fill out an application since the state does not have access to tribal government records.

If one student is Direct Certified, in a household, are the remaining students also Direct Certified?

Yes, if someone in the household is receiving Food Stamps (SNAP), TANF, or Food Distribution Program on Indian Reservations (FDPIR) all students in that household are eligible for free meals. Free meals because of foster status does not extend to the rest of the household but is an individual qualification.

USDA Nondiscrimination Statement

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Persons with disabilities who require alternative means of communication for program information (e.g. Braille, large print, audiotope, American Sign Language, etc.), should contact the Agency (State or local) where they applied for benefits. Individuals who are deaf, hard of hearing or have speech disabilities may contact USDA through the Federal Relay Service at (800) 877-8339. Additionally, program information may be made available in languages other than English.

To file a program complaint of discrimination, complete the USDA Program Discrimination Complaint Form, (AD-3027) found online at: http://www.ascr.usda.gov/complaint_filing_cust.html, and at any USDA office, or write a letter addressed to USDA and provide in the letter all of the information requested in the form. To request a copy of the complaint form, call (866) 632-9992. Submit your completed form or letter to USDA by:

(1) mail: U.S. Department of Agriculture Office of the Assistant Secretary for Civil Rights 1400 Independence Avenue, SW Washington, D.C. 20250-9410;

(2) fax: (202) 690-7442; or

(3) email: program.intake@usda.gov.

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